

Psalms 52

The Green Olive Tree

I am like a green olive tree in the house of God
KJV · Standalone study handout

1 • THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 *Why boastest thou thyself in mischief, O mighty man? the goodness of God endureth continually.*
- 2 *Thy tongue deviseth mischiefs; like a sharp razor, working deceitfully.*
- 3 *Thou lovest evil more than good; and lying rather than to speak righteousness. Selah.*
- 4 *Thou lovest all devouring words, O thou deceitful tongue.*
- 5 *God shall likewise destroy thee for ever, he shall take thee away, and pluck thee out of thy dwelling place, and root thee out of the land of the living. Selah.*
- 6 *The righteous also shall see, and fear, and shall laugh at him:*
- 7 *Lo, this is the man that made not God his strength; but trusted in the abundance of his riches, and strengthened himself in his wickedness.*
- 8 *But I am like a green olive tree in the house of God: I trust in the mercy of God for ever and ever.*
- 9 *I will praise thee for ever, because thou hast done it: and I will wait on thy name; for it is good before thy saints.*

2 • CONTEXT

Superscription connects this to Doeg the Edomite's betrayal of David to Saul (1 Sam 21–22), when Doeg reported that the priest Ahimelech had helped David, leading to the priests' slaughter. Henry reads the psalm as a rebuke to the "mighty man" who boasts in mischief and deceit, contrasted with the psalmist's quiet trust. MacArthur-style notes highlight the wisdom-psalm shape: a wicked man's doom versus the righteous man's rootedness, echoing Psalm 1's two ways.

3 • VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.

Verse 1-4

"Why boastest thou thyself in mischief, O mighty man?... Thy tongue deviseth mischiefs; like a sharp razor, working deceitfully." Doeg's crime was a lying tongue used for advantage and violence dressed as loyalty. Boasting in evil while God's goodness continues is folly, not strength.

Verse 5-7

God's answer is certain ruin: He "shall likewise destroy thee for ever," pluck him from his dwelling, and "root thee out of the land of the living." The righteous will see, fear, and laugh at one who trusted in riches and strengthened himself in wickedness rather than in God.

Verse 8-9

In contrast David says, "I am like a green olive tree in the house of God: I trust in the mercy of God for ever and ever." He resolves to praise God forever for what He has done and to wait on His name, since it is good, before the saints.

4 • MEANING & APPLICATION

Meaning.

The psalm sets two lives side by side—the boasting, deceitful "mighty man" rooted out like a dead tree, and the trusting believer flourishing like a green olive planted in God's own house. Security and fruitfulness come from where, and in whom, a life is rooted, not from cunning or power.

Application for life today.

Betrayal and slander can tempt you either toward despair or toward matching the enemy's tactics; instead, entrust judgment to God as David does. Examine whether your security rests on cleverness, wealth, or connections ("mighty man") or on being planted in God's house. Let long-term trust ("for ever and ever") shape a life of patient, visible fruitfulness rather than short-term maneuvering.

5 • REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no "right length" answers—honesty before God is the aim.

1. Where have you seen someone "boast in mischief" and prosper for a season—how does this psalm reframe that?

2. What would it mean this week to be "like a green olive tree in the house of God" rather than anxiously self-reliant?

3. How can you wait on God's name "for it is good" in a situation where vindication feels slow?

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group / Church: _____

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, *Commentary on the Whole Bible* (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).